

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Nail Technician English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Nail technicians, manicurists, pedicurists, and nail-salon reception staff.

All scenarios, prices, products, records, and incidents are fictional language practice. This is not instruction in nail preparation, application, removal, disinfection, chemical handling, or medical assessment. Qualified staff must determine service suitability and follow current product instructions and local requirements. Do not diagnose nail or skin conditions from these exercises.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Clarifying the service and the intended length

Distinguish a client's visual preference from a booking name.

02 Comparing shape and practical length

Distinguish shape from length when discussing samples.

03 Explaining color, coverage, and finish

Distinguish shine from coverage without confusing them with product type.

04 Agreeing on nail art and a complete quote

Negotiate the number of decorated nails using the supplied prices.

05 Responding to discomfort and uncertain nail concerns

Acknowledge an appearance goal while keeping an unassessed concern explicit.

06 Giving a clear station-readiness update

Separate visual tidiness from confirmed service readiness.

07 Handling a chip or design concern

Acknowledge a recorded design error and offer a bounded review.

08 Scheduling follow-up and handing over exact requests

Distinguish a requested appointment from confirmed service details.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Clarifying the service and the intended length

Distinguish a client's visual preference from a booking name.

CASE

A client booked an overlay but calls it a full set and points to a long reference image. They actually want to keep their current short length. No work has begun. Clarify length and explain why the image does not automatically mean extensions.

Teach this move

Terms such as full set can be used loosely. Ask about added length explicitly rather than treating a photograph as a complete instruction.

Vocabulary to check: manicure, pedicure, overlay, extension.

Model response

You've booked an overlay, and you said you want to keep your current short length. The photograph shows added length, so let's separate its color from its shape. Are you asking for the pictured color on your existing length, or do you want extensions?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The question lets the client separate independent choices.

Second-round challenge

The client says overlay and extension sound interchangeable. Explain the length distinction plainly.

Language-check answers

1. B - overlay Correct. An overlay covers the natural nail without deliberately adding length.
2. A - whether you want to keep your length Correct. The indirect question uses normal statement order.

05 • Conversations

1. Long reference, short request - A nail technician clarifies an overlay booking.
2. Hands or feet on the booking? - Reception checks an unclear online service selection.
3. One longer nail does not define the whole request - A client brings a reference showing mixed nail lengths.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A gift booking names the wrong service

A friend booked a pedicure for a recipient who wants a manicure. A hand-service appointment is available tomorrow at eleven; today's pedicure slot cannot be converted.

Role A: Receptionist: clarify hands versus feet and offer the stated alternative.

Role B: Client: prefer tomorrow's manicure and want the friend informed without discussing personal details.

Possible opening: The gift says pedicure, but I meant my hands.

Success checks

- Identify the requested service plainly.
- Do not silently add another service.
- Confirm tomorrow's manicure and removal of today's booking.

Add a complication: The client asks whether both services can fit into the original slot.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Comparing shape and practical length

Distinguish shape from length when discussing samples.

CASE

A client likes a long almond sample but needs a short result for keyboard work. A short squoval sample is also available. Compare the sample silhouettes and lengths without promising that either shape will prevent breakage or discomfort.

Teach this move

Two samples can differ on more than one dimension. Name the outline and length separately so a preference for one does not silently select the other.

Vocabulary to check: free edge, squoval, almond shape, swatch.

Model response

The almond sample narrows toward the tip, whereas this short squoval sample has a flatter end with softer corners. Their lengths differ too, so shape alone isn't the comparison. Since you prefer a short result for keyboard work, let's discuss the shorter reference before deciding what suits your nails.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The explanation names observable differences without a universal ranking.

Second-round challenge

The client assumes selecting the short sample guarantees it will never snag. Avoid an unsupported promise.

Language-check answers

1. A - squoval Correct. Squoval combines a square-like end with softened corners.
2. D - free edge Correct. The free edge extends beyond the fingertip.

05 • Conversations

1. A shorter sample changes the comparison - A client compares almond and squoval samples.
2. Even length or the longest nail? - A technician checks what a client means by matching lengths.
3. The color swatch is on a long tip - A client worries that choosing a swatch selects its length.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A photographed angle hides the length

A client brings a side-angle image and asks for 'the same short shape.' A front-view reference is available, showing a longer pointed tip. The client wants a short rounded outline.

Role A: Technician: compare views and confirm the requested outline.

Role B: Client: reject the long tip revealed in the front view.

Possible opening: It looked much shorter from the side in this photograph.

Success checks

- Identify which pictured feature is rejected.
- Separate camera angle from actual length.
- Restate the short rounded request.

Add a complication: The client keeps saying 'the same' after rejecting one feature.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Explaining color, coverage, and finish

Distinguish shine from coverage without confusing them with product type.

CASE

A client requests matte pink but selects a sheer glossy swatch. They want a low-shine appearance with the nail line still visible. The booking does not specify lacquer or gel polish. Explain finish versus coverage and leave product selection open.

Teach this move

A color name does not specify coverage, finish, or product system. Explain each choice using the client's actual description.

Vocabulary to check: lacquer, gel polish, sheer, matte.

Model response

Matte describes the low-shine finish, whereas sheer describes how much of your nail remains visible. You want a sheer pink with less shine, not necessarily an opaque color. This swatch is glossy, so it doesn't show both preferences. We still need to discuss the product choice separately.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The explanation separates two independent properties.

Second-round challenge

The client thinks a glossy swatch proves a matte version will be identical apart from shine. Offer comparison without guaranteeing an exact match.

Language-check answers

1. D - sheer Correct. Sheer color allows the underlying nail to show.
2. C - finish Correct. Finish describes the shiny or low-shine appearance here.

05 • Conversations

1. Sheer and matte answer different questions - A technician clarifies a pink color request.
2. A color name does not identify a product - A client brings an old receipt showing only a shade name.

3. Opaque was not the requested effect - A client compares two pink samples at reception.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The shade code stays the same but the finish changes

A client wants the same blue shade code, B12, as last visit but a matte rather than glossy appearance. No matching matte sample has been reviewed.

Role A: Technician: confirm B12 as the retained blue shade preference and distinguish it from the changed finish.

Role B: Client: want blue B12 with less shine; do not want a different blue chosen silently.

Possible opening: Can I keep blue B12 but make it less shiny?

Success checks

- Confirm the retained blue shade code B12.
- Name the changed finish.
- Avoid guaranteeing identical appearance across lighting conditions.

Add a complication: The client assumes the same code guarantees an identical appearance under every light.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Agreeing on nail art and a complete quote

Negotiate the number of decorated nails using the supplied prices.

CASE

A fictional base service costs \$30. Simple line art is \$5 per nail, with no other charges in this exercise. The client wants four decorated nails but has a \$40 limit. Offer two decorated nails for \$40 or the base service alone for \$30.

Teach this move

State whether a charge applies per nail, per hand, or to the whole design. Confirm the selected nails as well as the total.

Vocabulary to check: accent nail, nail art, embellishment, service quote.

Model response

The base service is thirty dollars, and the line art is five dollars per nail. Four decorated nails would total fifty, above your forty-dollar limit. Two accent nails would bring the total to forty. Would you prefer those two, or the thirty-dollar base service without the design?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The unit of price prevents a misleading total.

Second-round challenge

The client requests an embellishment not included in the line-art quote. Keep its price unconfirmed.

Language-check answers

1. C - per decorated nail Correct. The supplied quote charges for each decorated nail.
2. B - provided that we limit the line art to two nails Correct. 'Provided that' states the condition that keeps the agreed scope within budget.

05 • Conversations

1. Four designs exceed the stated limit - A client has a forty-dollar budget. Fictional final prices are thirty for the base service and five per line-art nail, with no other charges.
2. The design has a front and a back - A technician checks the orientation of lettering in a design.

3. An embellishment was only an idea - A client clarifies that a design question was not a purchase decision.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A design is too detailed for the reserved time

A forty-minute appointment covers plain color. The detailed reference design needs a separate sixty-minute booking, available Friday at two. A simple one-line design fits today's stated slot and adds \$5.

Role A: Technician: offer today's simple option or Friday's longer appointment.

Role B: Client: prefer the detailed design and can attend Friday.

Possible opening: Can we add everything in this photograph to today's booking?

Success checks

- Separate the two design scopes.
- Use the stated appointment lengths and price limit accurately.
- Confirm Friday for the detailed design with its quote still to be discussed.

Add a complication: The client asks for the full design at the simple design's extra price.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Responding to discomfort and uncertain nail concerns

Acknowledge an appearance goal while keeping an unassessed concern explicit.

CASE

Before any service starts, a client reports unexplained tenderness beside one nail and asks you to cover it with product for an event. Pause that service request and refer the health concern to an appropriate healthcare professional without diagnosing or suggesting treatment. Explain that the salon must separately decide whether the cosmetic service is suitable; referral does not promise service approval.

Teach this move

Use the client's own symptom words. Distinguish a reported feeling, an observed change, and an unknown cause. Refer the health concern to an appropriate healthcare professional; salon staff separately decide whether the cosmetic service is suitable without diagnosing the cause.

Vocabulary to check: nail plate, cuticle, lifting, tenderness.

Model response

I understand you want the nail to look finished for the event. You've reported unexplained tenderness, so let's pause this request and refer the health concern to an appropriate healthcare professional. I can't diagnose its cause. The salon must separately assess whether the cosmetic service is suitable; the referral doesn't guarantee that we'll proceed.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised wording neither minimizes nor invents a diagnosis.

Second-round challenge

The client says a friend called it harmless. Acknowledge the report without adopting that conclusion.

Language-check answers

1. B - unassessed Correct. No assessment has established the cause of the soreness.

2. A - lifting Correct. Lifting describes separation of the enhancement from the natural nail.

05 • Conversations

1. An event does not answer a suitability question - A client raises tenderness before a nail service.
2. The client names the wrong area - A technician helps a client locate a reported concern.
3. A lifting report without a cause - A client asks about separation at the edge of a coating.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 • Say it: second scenario | A strong smell prompts a pause

During a consultation, a client reports that a product odor bothers them and asks to stop. The technician has not applied product. The manager can discuss the concern immediately.

Role A: Technician: pause the service discussion and communicate the reported concern.

Role B: Client: want to move away from the station and talk to the manager, not receive a diagnosis.

Possible opening: Could we stop? That smell is bothering me.

Success checks

- Use the client's words rather than an invented diagnosis.
- Confirm that application has not begun.
- Arrange the stated manager discussion while keeping the service paused.

Add a complication: A colleague calls the concern an allergy without any assessment.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Giving a clear station-readiness update

Separate visual tidiness from confirmed service readiness.

CASE

Station three is tidy, but its required readiness checks are incomplete. Station two has been confirmed ready by the responsible technician. A client is waiting. Offer station two without calling station three ready or providing disinfection instructions.

Teach this move

Give a concise status and a verified alternative. Do not turn this language exercise into instructions for disinfectant use or tool preparation.

Vocabulary to check: reusable implement, single-use item, disinfection, contact time.

Model response

Station three is tidy, but its required readiness checks are not complete. Station two has been confirmed ready, so we can offer that space instead. If you prefer station three, I can update you when its status is confirmed, but I don't have a reliable waiting estimate yet.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The update avoids treating appearance as confirmation.

Second-round challenge

The client asks for a specific waiting time nobody has confirmed. Offer the verified alternative without inventing minutes.

Language-check answers

1. A - incomplete Correct. The required checks have not been finished.
2. D - disinfectant's specified contact period Correct. The term refers to the product's specified period, not conversation.

05 • Conversations

1. Tidy does not mean ready - A technician gives a waiting client a station update.

2. A colleague needs the status, not a procedure - Two technicians clarify an incomplete station note.

3. A label question deserves a specific answer - A client asks about a packaged item before a service.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A station change needs a new message

Reception told a client station five was available, but the lead has now marked it unavailable pending a check. Station one is ready, and the client's usual technician can work there.

Role A: Technician: correct the earlier station message with no invented cause.

Role B: Client: prefer the same technician and accept station one.

Possible opening: Reception said I could sit at five. Has that changed?

Success checks

- State the changed status.
- Offer the confirmed station and same technician.
- Avoid speculating about the reason for the check.

Add a complication: The client assumes a station change means the appointment is cancelled.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Handling a chip or design concern

Acknowledge a recorded design error and offer a bounded review.

CASE

A client requested line art facing them, but the finished lettering faces away. The service record confirms the client's original direction. A review is available today at four with no review fee. Do not promise a particular correction before assessment.

Teach this move

Separate the confirmed mismatch from the remedy, which may still require assessment and agreement.

Vocabulary to check: chip, snag, repair appointment, service record.

Model response

Our service note says the lettering should face you, and the current direction doesn't match that request. I'm sorry we missed that detail. We can review it today at four without a review fee. We'll discuss the suitable correction and any terms before you decide, rather than assume a particular remedy.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The response addresses the actual mismatch without shifting blame.

Second-round challenge

The client interprets a free review as a promise of a free full new set. Clarify what has actually been offered.

Language-check answers

1. D - orientation Correct. Orientation describes the direction in which the letters face.
2. C - fee Correct. The review has no charge.

05 • Conversations

1. The letters face the wrong way - A technician acknowledges a recorded design mismatch.
2. A small chip with an unknown cause - A receptionist arranges a service review for a client.
3. An edge catches on a sleeve - A technician clarifies a client's report without prescribing a home repair.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 • Say it: second scenario | One missing decorative detail

The agreed design included a white dot on two accent nails; one finished accent nail has no dot. The base color is correct. A technician can review it in twenty minutes.

Role A: Technician: acknowledge the missing detail and offer review.

Role B: Client: want only the missing dot discussed, not the entire design replaced.

Possible opening: This nail has the dot we agreed on, but the other one doesn't.

Success checks

- Correct the inaccurate color description.
- Identify the one missing design element.
- Confirm the review timing without inventing a remedy.

Add a complication: Reception describes the issue as a wrong color.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Scheduling follow-up and handing over exact requests

Distinguish a requested appointment from confirmed service details.

CASE

A client requested plain color next Friday at ten but also reports an unidentified existing product. Reception must arrange a consultation before confirming removal time or an infill. The client declines nail art. Friday is a requested time, not yet booked.

Teach this move

State the existing product as unknown rather than guessing its identity. Pass the actual next task to the receiving colleague.

Vocabulary to check: removal appointment, infill, booking deposit, consultation.

Model response

The client wants plain color next Friday at ten and has declined nail art. They report an existing product but cannot identify it, so removal time and any infill suitability remain unconfirmed. Please arrange a consultation and check availability. Friday at ten is their request, not a confirmed appointment.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The handover preserves the unknown detail instead of choosing a technical service.

Second-round challenge

The client finds a receipt with only a color name. Explain why the product identity remains open.

Language-check answers

1. C - requested Correct. The client has asked for it, but availability is unconfirmed.
2. B - advance payment Correct. A booking deposit is payment made in advance under stated terms.

05 • Conversations

1. Friday is a preference, not a booking - A technician hands a scheduling query to reception.

2. An infill request needs its own discussion - Reception clarifies a returning client's maintenance request.

3. The deposit terms need a read-back - A receptionist explains a fictional deposit arrangement.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A removal request is added after booking

A client booked a forty-minute plain-color appointment but now reports an existing product needing assessment for removal. The technician can offer a consultation today; a longer service slot is available Monday, subject to assessment.

Role A: Receptionist: explain why the original slot does not confirm the added service.

Role B: Client: can attend Monday but need the price before agreeing.

Possible opening: Can you just include removal in my original appointment time?

Success checks

- Keep time availability separate from service suitability.
- Preserve the unknown product information.
- Confirm a consultation rather than invent a removal method or price.

Add a complication: The client thinks a longer slot automatically confirms the product is removable by that service.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All scenarios, prices, products, records, and incidents are fictional language practice. This is not instruction in nail preparation, application, removal, disinfection, chemical handling, or medical assessment. Qualified staff must determine service suitability and follow current product instructions and local requirements. Do not diagnose nail or skin conditions from these exercises.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Manicurists and Pedicurists

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/personal-care-and-service/manicurists-and-pedicurists.htm>

OSHA: Health Hazards in Nail Salons

<https://www.osha.gov/nail-salons>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.